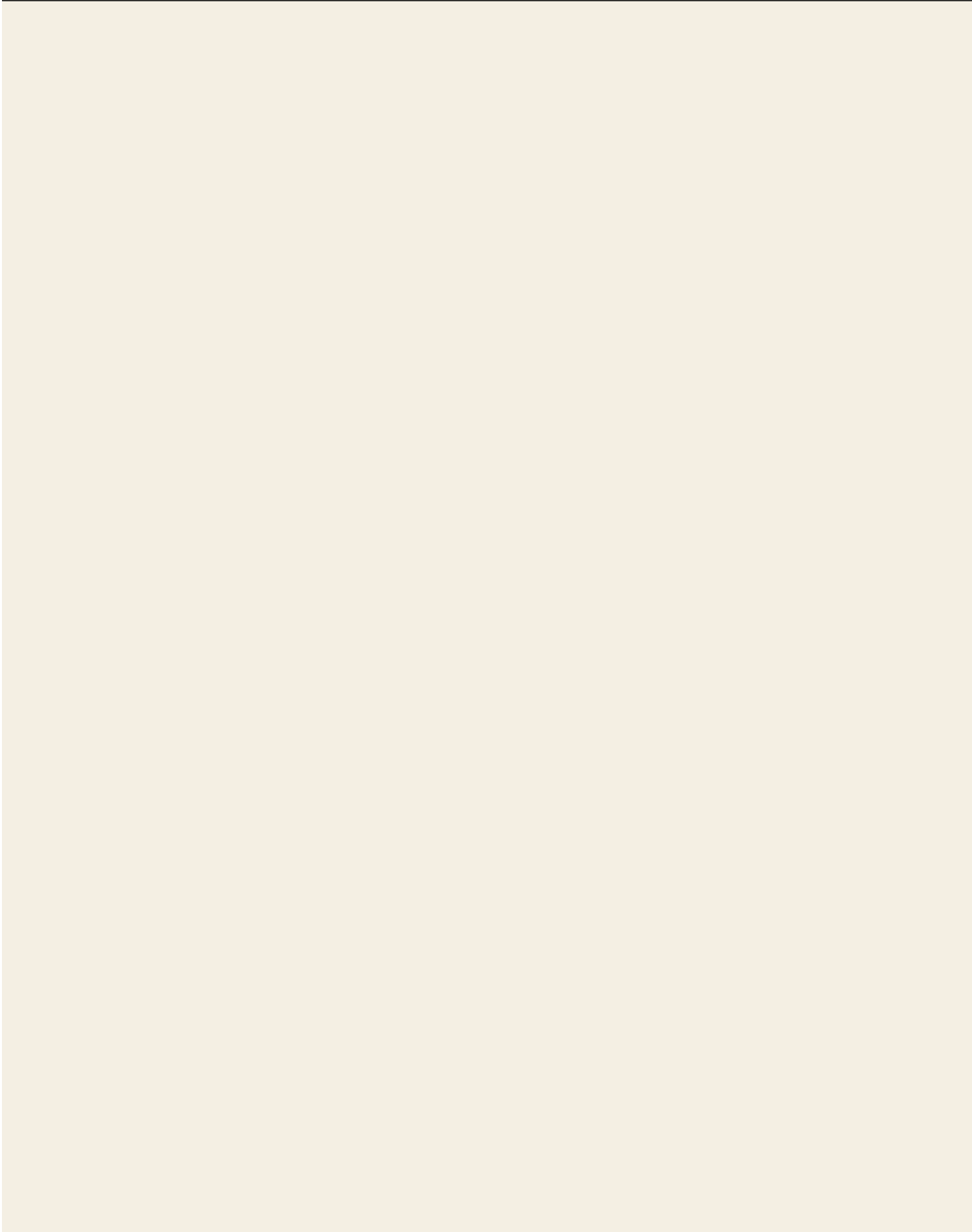




A FIELD MANUAL · VOLUME 01

NO. 0001 · INTERNAL REFERENCE

A BRAND IN THREE PARTS: MARKS · VOICE · PARAPHERNALIA

curate.

*A field guide to the marks,
palette, and paraphernalia of a
record & bookshop, est. 2026.*

PUBLISHED

Summer 2026
Northern New Mexico

EDITION

v1.0
Internal Reference

FOR

Owners, partners,
and printmakers.

STATUS

Living document.
Subject to revision.

§ 01 — Manifesto

01

WHERE WE START, WHAT WE SOUND LIKE

A brand is the sum of small, repeated decisions. This manual is the short list of ours — written down so the next sign, sticker, and sleeve looks like it came from the same shop as the last.

*Where the needle
drops **and the book**
falls open.*

Curate is a record store and a bookshop sharing one front door — plus a record club that meets you wherever you are. The shelves hold vinyl, hardcover, used and new. The club is the part we do differently: a real human curator picks one to three records a month for each member, based on a personal interview, a short questionnaire, and your listening history. (Borrowed, gratefully, from Heywood Hill's century of doing the same for books in London.) For walk-ins, there's a kiosk at the back of the shop. For everyone else, a virtual curator on the site.

Our brand should feel like all three rooms — hand-painted, well-lit, and a little stubborn. Read this end to end before you make anything new — it's short on rules and long on examples, because the difference between a brand and a logo is the muscle memory of doing it the same way twice.

*— with love, from the back of the
shop.*

The mark, four ways.

One drawing, four wrappers. The wordmark and the circle are the family heads. Everything else is them in different clothes.

A · PRIMARY MARK

USE ON DARK GROUNDS · $\geq 32\text{PX}$

B · WORDMARK



ON CREAM · FOR HEADERS, PACKAGING

C · HORIZONTAL LOCKUP



RECORDS AND BOOKS

VERTICAL · WITH TAGLINE

D · CIRCULAR LOCKUP



ROUND · WITH TAGLINE · STICKERS, SOCIAL

CLEAR SPACE & ANATOMY

Give it room to breathe.

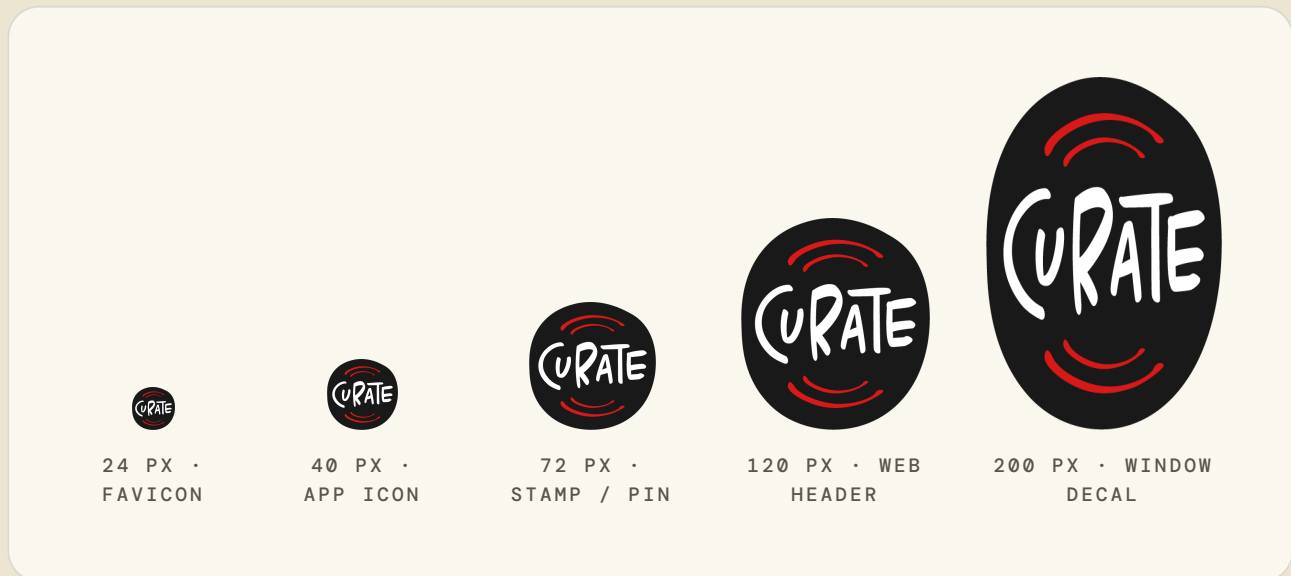
Minimum clear space on all sides equals X — the height of the "C" in CURATE measured at the size you're using. Nothing — text, edges, gradients, other logos — enters that buffer.

- **Don't crop the circle.** The disk is read as a vinyl record — clipping it kills the metaphor.



- **Keep the three arcs.** They're the sound waves. Top two + bottom two are deliberate; don't drop one.
- **Lowercase 'u' is intentional.** The lettering is hand-drawn, not a font — never re-typeset.

MINIMUM SIZES



MISUSE — DON'T

Four ways to ruin it.

DON'T • 01



Don't stretch or distort. The letterforms are hand-drawn — they don't survive scaling.

DON'T • 02



Don't tilt the circle. The arcs are oriented — top and bottom matter.

DON'T • 03



Don't drop the mark over gradients or photography without an opaque ground.

DON'T • 04



Don't recolor. Curate Red and Vinyl Black are the only color combinations.

Three colors, used like seasoning.

Cream is the room. Vinyl black is the furniture. Red is the lipstick — punctual, never a wash. Everything else is paper and ink.

§ 03 — Palette

PRIMARY SURFACE • 60%

Bone Cream

The room. The page. The default canvas for everything on paper.

HEX #F4EFE3

RGB 244 • 239 • 227

CMYK 03 • 04 • 11 • 00

PMS Warm Gray 1C (closest)

INK & WEIGHT • 25%

Vinyl Black

Type, the disk, dark slabs. Warm rather than absolute — never pure #000.

HEX #1D1D1B

RGB 29 • 29 • 27

CMYK 67 • 60 • 62 •

92

PMS Black 6 C

(closest)

ACCENT & SIGNAL • 15%

Curate Red

The brand voice. CTAs, accents, the "+" of every lockup. Used in measured doses.

HEX #DB1D1B

RGB 219 • 29 • 27

CMYK 10 • 96 • 95 •

02

PMS 485 C (closest)

SUPPORT PALETTE · PAPER, INK, SIGNAGE

Sleeve White
Card backs, second surface.

HEX #ECE5D2

Kraft
Hang tags, paper bags, twine.

HEX #C9A878

Sleeve Mustard
Special-edition accents only.

HEX #D9A441

Deep Rust
Stamp ink. Print drops only.

HEX #8B2418

RULES

A few hard lines.

- **Never red on black, black on red.** The combo vibrates. Always separate them with cream.
- **Cream over white.** Pure white is for the inside of paper bags only.
- **Red is accent, not surface.** Maximum 15% of any composition by area.
- **Support colors are seasonal.** Mustard for summer/jazz, rust for fall/classics — confirm before adopting.

TESTED · ACCESSIBILITY

All approved combos pass WCAG AA at body size.

INK ON CREAM
Records and books.
14.2 : 1 · AAA

CREAM ON BLACK
Records and books.
15.4 : 1 · AAA

CREAM ON RED
Records and books.
5.6 : 1 · AA

RED ON CREAM
Records and books.
4.9 : 1 · AA

A small typeface family with a part-time job.

The logo does the heavy lifting. Supporting type stays out of its way: one chunky display, one editorial italic, one workhorse sans, one chalkboard hand.

§ 04 — Type

DISPLAY · FOR SECTION HEADERS, SIGNAGE, THE LOUD
MOMENTS

Side A.

Archivo Black

GOOGLE FONTS ·
REGULAR ONLY ·
OMNIBUS-TYPE

*A squared-off heavy
sans built for
punchy headlines
and signage. No
serifs, no soft*

*terminals — just
blocks of type.
Naturally well-
spaced, reads bold
without reading
rounded.*

A B C D E F G H I
J K L M N O P Q R
S T U V W X Y Z Ø
1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9
& + ?

EDITORIAL · FOR BOOK-SIDE MOMENTS,
QUOTES, LEDE PARAGRAPHS

*First
edition.*

Newsreader Italic

GOOGLE FONTS · 300 / 400 / 500

*Calm, literate, with a slight
letterpress warmth. Used for italic
lede paragraphs, quotes, and any
moment where the bookshop talks.*

a b c d e f g h i j k l m n o p q
r s t u v w x y z

BODY · FOR EVERYTHING ELSE — UI,
CAPTIONS, PARAGRAPHS

Now
playing.

Familjen Grotesk

GOOGLE FONTS · 400 / 500 / 700

*A Scandinavian sans with a touch of
warmth in its terminals. Used at
small sizes where the brand needs to
get out of the way and just be legible
— without disappearing.*

a b c d e f g h i j k l m n o p q
r s t u v w x y z

HAND • FOR CHALKBOARDS, HANGTAGS,
"TODAY ONLY" MOMENTS

today
only!

Caveat

GOOGLE FONTS • 600 / 700

*The shop-clerk's marker. Reserved for
the chalkboard outside, hangtag fills,
and the occasional flourish on a
receipt. Never used for headlines.*

*the quick brown fox jumps over the lazy
dog & finds a first edition.*

HIERARCHY • IN PRACTICE

DISPLAY H1

ARCHIVO BLACK • 84 / 88 •
-1%

New arrivals.

DISPLAY H2

ARCHIVO BLACK • 56 / 56 •
-0.5%

Side B picks.

EDITORIAL

NEWSREADER ITALIC • 30 / 36

*An undersung jazz pianist
whose late records read like
short stories.*

LEDE / BODY LG
FAMILJEN GROTESK · 18 / 27

We sell vinyl, hardcover, and used paperbacks. We don't sell candles. Open Tuesday through Sunday, eleven to seven.

BODY
FAMILJEN GROTESK · 15 / 23

A short paragraph in body type. Used for everything that isn't a headline, label, or pull quote — captions, descriptions, the back of a card. Always set in cream-on-black, ink-on-cream, or cream-on-red.

EYEBROW / LABEL
DM MONO · 11 / 1.8 · 0.22EM

SECTION · NOW PLAYING

HANDWRITTEN
CAVEAT · 38 / 40

— *back Tuesday!*

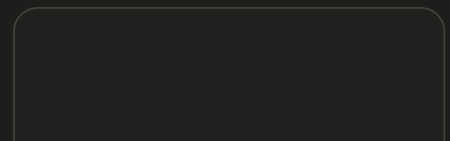
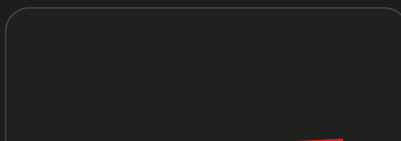
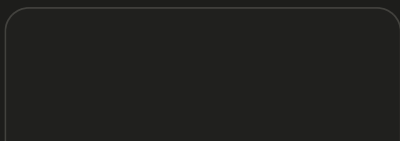
Three patterns. None of them busy.

Pulled directly from the mark: the grooves on a record, the arcs above and below the wordmark, the halftone dot of a printed sticker.

§ 05 — Pattern



STAMPS & POSTMARKS · FOR RECEIPTS, PACKAGING, "USED" STICKERS





— SHELF NOTE —
**SIGNED
 FIRST
 EDITION**
 No. ____ / ____

— PICK OF THE WEEK —
**STAFF
 RECOMMENDS**

Speak like the shopkeeper, not the shop.

Plain, warm, slightly opinionated. Confident enough to recommend, modest enough to be wrong sometimes. Em-dashes earn their keep — short sentences carry the rest.

§ 06 — Voice

Do. *"New in. Worth your Saturday."*

Don't.  **ABSOLUTELY
MUST-HAVE**

Direct, declarative, with a quiet recommendation built in. The shopkeeper knows what's good.

*RELEASES YOU
CAN'T MISS!! 🔥*

Hype-shaped, all-caps, emoji-loaded.
We're not a TikTok shop.

Do. *"Used hardcovers —
half-priced. The good
kind of musty."*

A specific detail, a slight wink, no apologies for what it is.

Don't. *"Pre-loved literary
treasures at exceptional
value."*

Real-estate-listing language. Hides the thing it's selling.

Do. *"Closed Mondays. Back
Tuesday with coffee."*

A small joke, a small promise. Treats the customer like a neighbor.

Don't. *"Please be advised of our
hours of operation."*

Sounds like a parking sign. The brand isn't a corporation.

WORDS WE LIKE

Side A. Side B. New arrivals. Used & well-loved. First pressing. Out-of-print. Dog-eared. Spine-cracked. Staff pick. Pick of the week. Now playing. Now reading. Back Tuesday. Last copies. Hand-numbered. Worth your Saturday.

WORDS WE DON'T

~~*Curate (as a verb). Iconic. Disruptive. Pre-loved. Treasures. Hidden gems. Exquisite. Bespoke. Game-changing. Drop. Hype. Must-have. Vibes. Aesthetic. Era.*~~

— Curating is what the customer does in here. We just stock the shelves.

Paper goods.

The small print things — cards, tags, letterhead.

Always cream or kraft stock, never gloss. The mark always shows up bigger than feels comfortable, on at least one side.

§ 07 — Stationery

A • BUSINESS CARDS

88 × 50 mm
Letterpress
two-sided.

Front: name, role, contact in DM Mono

Back: the circle mark, full bleed, blind
debossed on black stock. Heavy 600 gsm
cotton; the edges painted Curate Red.



B • LETTERHEAD

**A5,
single-
side,
signed.**

Header: the
brandmark at 36px
on the left, shop info
aligned right in DM
Mono 8px. The body
is always typewritten
or hand-signed — no
all-cream marketing
fluff.



C • GIFT CARD

**Red
carrier.
Black
disk.
Cream
type.**

Plastic 86 × 54 mm card with
rounded corners. The disk eats
one corner — a deliberate
quote of the brand mark.
Numbers are stamped, not



printed; each card gets a
unique ID.

Things to carry the shop out of the shop.

Restrained. Built to outlive trends. A tote, a sticker, a pin, a sleeve, a tee, a bookmark, a mug — that's the whole catalog for year one.

§ 08 — Merch

A · COTTON TOTE



"It carries 14 LPs. We checked."

B · STICKER PACK · ×4



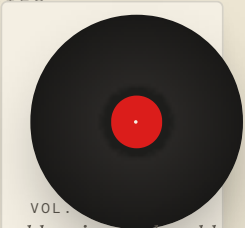
"For your laptop, water bottle, or notebook."

C · ENAMEL PIN · 32MM



"Hand-numbered. First 200 only."

D · 7" SLEEVE · MIXTAPE SERIES



"Monthly mixtape, hand-burned to vinyl."

E · HEAVYWEIGHT TEE · BLACK



"Heavyweight 8oz cotton. Made to fade well."

F · BOOKMARK SET · ×3



G · CERAMIC MUG · 12OZ



"Coffee mug for the back of the shop."

H · TURNTABLE SLIPMAT · 12"



"Felt slipmat. Quieter than the deck it lives on."

I · FIELD NOTEBOOK · A6, RED COVER



"A6 hardcover. For new finds and what to come back for."

From the street.

The awning is the loudest the brand ever gets.
Everything else — window decal, sandwich board,
chalkboard — speaks in quiet handwriting.

§ 09 — Signage



Now spinning

— side A · this
afternoon —

Astral Weeks — V.
Morrison \$22

Pink Moon — N. Drake \$28

Spirit of Eden — Talk
Talk \$34

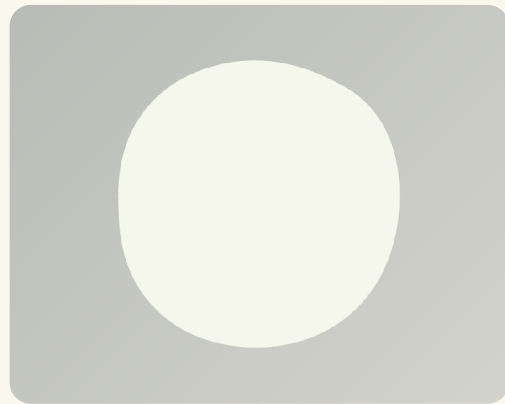
Hejira — J. Mitchell \$26

— ask us for side B!

WINDOW DECAL · VINYL, CUT TO
SHAPE

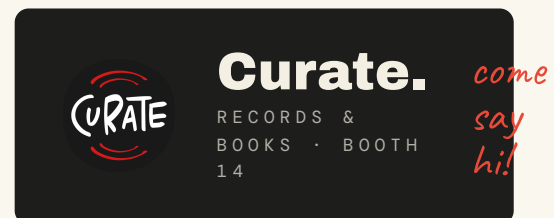
The brandmark, 200mm.

Single mark, dead center of the front
window. White vinyl on the glass — never on
the door, never alongside other stickers.



BANNER · LONG-FORM, RETRACTABLE

For markets & pop-ups.



Quiet feed, loud avatar.

The avatar is the circle mark on black, always. Posts use the wider palette and the four templates below — three "now" types, three "quote/recommend" types. Never daily; weekly at most.

§ 10 — Social

PROFILE AVATAR



280 × 280 px

Never wordmark. Never cropped. Always black ground.

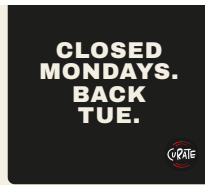
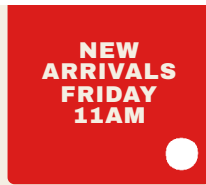
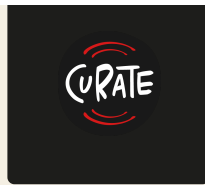
COVER BANNER • 1500 × 500



Red ground. Wordmark over circle mark. Always sits to the right.

POST TEMPLATES • 1080 × 1080

Six templates. Mix and match.



CAPTIONS · ON-VOICE

New Friday. A near-mint pressing of *Astral Weeks*, three first editions of Didion, and a stack of jazz 45s a man in a great coat left us on Tuesday. Tuesday through Sunday, eleven to seven. Coffee's on.

CAPTIONS · OFF-VOICE

 ~~HUGE DROP ALERT!!~~ Stop everything — we got iconic, **ICONIC** pressings + bestsellers you literally **NEED** in your collection. ~~Come thru!!~~ Link in bio & DM us 

Drop the **needle.**

— *That's the kit. Anything missing, ask.*

BRAND CUSTODIAN	SOURCE FILES	VERSION	SHOP
[TBD] hello @curate.shop	/brand/assets/ SVG · PNG · ICO	v1.0 – May 2026 Living document.	Northern New Mexico Off Route 66

